

# WATCHING THE LOCH



## MENTAL TIER 3

In the quaint community of Clearview Lake, there lurks a dark secret. A beautiful monster swims in these waters, never seen directly except in the dreams of the elderly residents. The nearby research lab has undergone a 'brain drain' as a result, losing esteemed doctors and scientists one by one to the more adventurous vocation of monster hunter. The only way to bring them back to work was to prove that an imaginary beast is real, leaving the laboratory head at a loss, so he decided if the monster didn't exist, he would have to make one.

## MOVES

**Generous Gifts:** Whenever the player eats fish gifted by Dr. Rhine, they take one Physical attribute change. Whenever the player is exposed to ultrasound scanning equipment by Dr. Rhine, they take one Mental attribute change.

**Those Dark Dreams:** Whenever the player sleeps without earplugs while within view of the lake, they take one change in any attribute.

## CAST

### PROFESSOR CHESTER D. GUNTHER (HE/HIM)

A once respected professor who lives in a large house on the lakeside. He retired, divorced his wife, and left his family of three children to live near the lake in search of the monster. As his only source of income, he rents out the spare bedrooms of the house and makes amateur taxidermy of fantastical beasts. When Dr. Rhine asks him to inject the lab's new hire with something in exchange for a promise that the monster will appear to him, he does it gladly.

### FRED AVRAM (HE/HIM)

A real estate agent in the area who the player is working with to find a house of their own. He calls them every day to go over options, but he is really trying to impede them. He's in on the plan with Dr. Rhine to turn the player into a lake monster, as he thinks it will make the property values skyrocket. If the player becomes too violent, that is not the sort of monster he was promised, and he uses his dirty connections with the cops to hunt the player down.

### DR. MALCOM RHINE (HE/HIM)

Head researcher at the Laboratory. He one of the few people living around the lake who is not convinced of the monster's existence, but sets out to make it real in hopes of curing the delusion of the other retired faculty. His research used to be at the cutting edge of regenerative medicine and ultrasound imaging thanks to the breakthroughs by Dr. Blanchet. Lately though, he has been reclusive and only concerned with his monster serum, making Dr. Blanchet suspicious of what he's up to.

**DR. PETERS SPURLING (HE/THEM)**

An assistant doctor deep into delusions about the lake monster. He believes that the lab's zebrafish are talking to him, telling him that the monster is living among the humans.

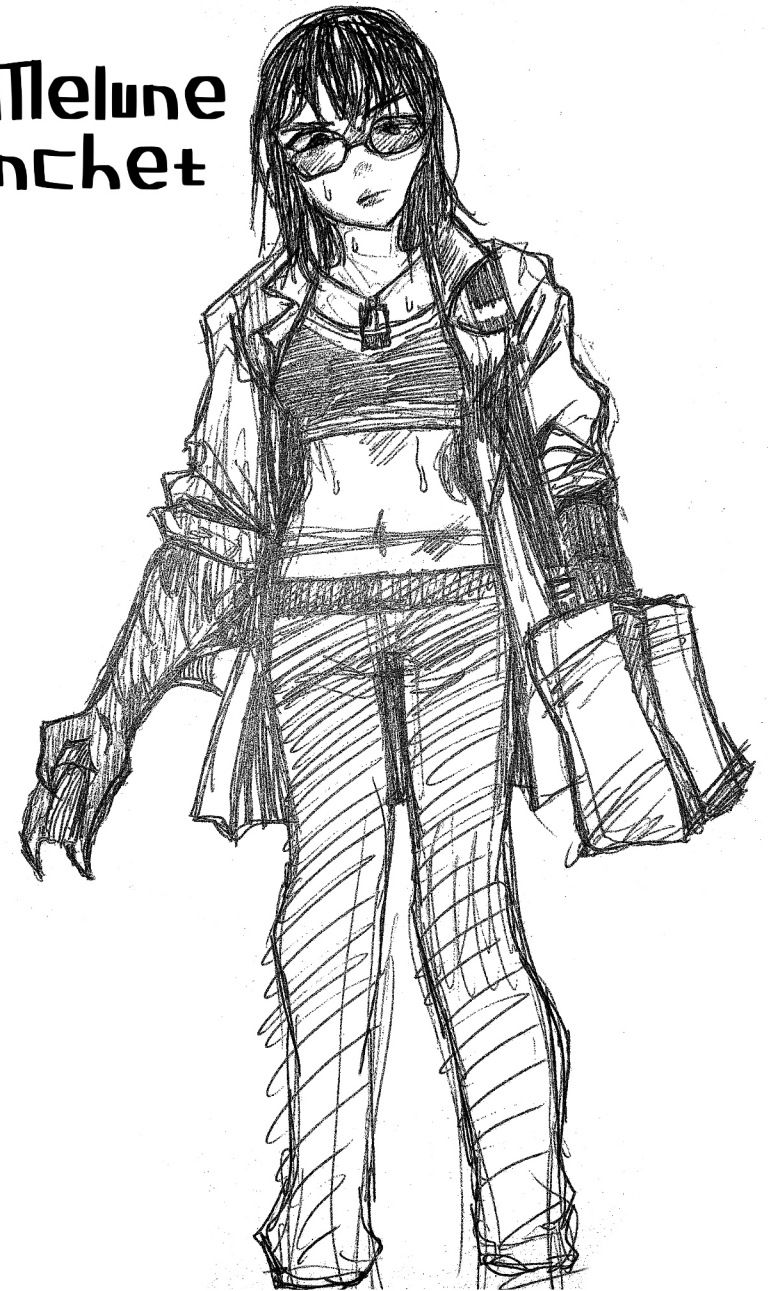
**ALISTER VONT (HE/HIM)**

A homeless trans man, who lives around the edge of the lake and keeps watch with his crossbow. Professors who live around the lake think he is a stalwart monster hunter, but in truth he sees himself as a monster protector, and his nightly rounds are to make sure the monster remains safe. He recalls an encounter in his youth where a lake monster came and healed him, as well as changing his gender. He instinctively knows that the player is not the real lake monster, so he will try to help the player if able, especially if they offer to help him find the real monster.

**DR. MELUNE BLANCHET (SHE/HER)**

The Melusine, a French draconic mermaid woman, who lives in hiding as the laboratories' star researcher. She realizes that her secret nightly swimming and singing is fueling the wild monster obsession of the locals, but she doesn't really care. A genius scientist, she lets Dr. Rhine take credit for all her research so that she can stay incognito. If the player asks her for help and show her two or more Physical changes, she will gladly develop a cure, though the process takes time. Splashing her with water reveals her true form temporarily.

# Dr. Melune Blanchet



## INTRO

The player is a new hire at the Bakers Regenerative Medicine and Imaging Laboratory, led by Dr. Rhine. They have been set up to stay in one of the spare rooms at Chester's house while they work with the real estate agent Fred Avram to find them a more long-term property to buy or rent.

In the meantime, they are to start work at the laboratory immediately, which is reachable by shuttle bus to a small island on the middle of Clearview Lake. The laboratory specializes in research using ultrasound imaging to study heart tissue regeneration in zebrafish models.

Dr. Rhine immediately sets the player to work with himself or Dr. Spurling. The player is most familiar with Dr. Blanchet's brilliant research, but she acts elusive and avoids making any friendly chit-chat.

## THE CHANGE

Before the first day of work, Chester injects the player with a serum while they are sleeping, starting the change. Chester doesn't know what the serum does, only that Dr. Rhine promised him it would make the lake monster appear.

In their sleep, the player has a restless dream of a beautiful female mer-creature calling their name. When they awaken, they take one Physical change and one Mental change. The player must also make a test against MF or else they become highly convinced that the lake monster is real.

## BUILDUP

After the player is injected, Dr. Rhine continually encourages them to work with the special ultrasound devices that trigger further changes. He also gives Chester lots of gifts of fresh fish that are laced with a substance that further activates the serum.

At the end of first day, the player gets a call from the head doctor of the nearby State Psychiatric Facility, warning the player about the high prevalence of delusions among the populace of the lake. They suspect that Dr. Rhine is being an abusive boss and the delusions of a 'lake monster' are a stress response to harmful working conditions at the laboratory. They ask the player to find evidence of his wrongdoing, and will become worried if the player describes their own mental changes.

If Dr. Blanchet sees the player with more than two physical changes and evidence that Dr. Rhine is behind it, she can reverse engineer a cure for the serum. She will ask the player to distract Dr. Rhine while she gets accesses his research. If Dr. Rhine suspects that Dr. Blanchet is helping the player, he will impede her and may even uncover her secret identity.

If Dr. Spurling sees the player with physical changes or acting oddly, he becomes convinced they are the monster and tries to trap them in the lab.

During the second night, the player also encounters Alister wandering the streets with his crossbow. He strikes a fearsome visage, but is quite friendly as long as the player is not a monster hunter.

# Alistair Vont



## CLIMAX

It takes Dr. Blanchet at least 24 hours to procure the cure. During the second day, Dr. Rhine send a message with a photo-shopped lake monster to all the retired professors and scientists in the community, getting them to spread across the lake looking for the changed player. If the player is being especially elusive at this point, Dr. Rhine brings in his private submarine equipped with ultrasound scanning technology to hunt them down.

If the player is cooperating with Dr. Blanchet or Alistair, they both ask that the player not be spotted, as the resulting national attention would likely put Dr. Blanchet and the player's lives in grave danger.

## ENDINGS

If the player is caught and photographed, Dr. Blanchet will make plans to escape the laboratory before more monster hunters show up, abandoning the player's cure.

If player reaches permanence but is not caught, they can live in the lake alongside Dr. Blanchet, though life becomes much more difficult for both of them.

The player can also try to expose Dr. Blanchet's true form in front of Dr. Rhine, which causes her to become the hunted monster and lets the player escape scrutiny. For the player to develop their own cure takes multiple successful tests to MF and a small sample of Dr. Blanchet's blood or scales.

If the player talks to Alistair, he can show the player a sewer passageway to the old water gate, from when



Clearview Lake used to be a reservoir. With successful tests to PA and PF, the player can drain the lake and escape into a small river which eventually takes them out to sea.

If Alister and Dr. Blanchet are reunited, he alone can convince her to safely leave the lake and find a new home in secret elsewhere, vowing to always protect her. When Dr. Blanchet leaves, the retired professors and scientists stop obsessing over a lake monster, looking for a new type of cryptid to hunt instead.

### CLUES & EXTRAS

- Dr. Blanchet's blood and scales have magical healing properties, so she always keeps a vial of her blood on hand inside the pendant of her necklace, for emergencies. This can be used to heal damage or help reverse engineer the cure.
- Dr. Blanchet's blood is also the source of her ability to make amazing breakthroughs in regenerative medicine, though she is a capable scientist on her own right.
- If the player tries to snoop on Dr. Rhine's suspicious lack of recent research, they can find evidence that he was using laboratory funds to purchase an authentic plesiosaur fossil. *Now why would he need that?*
- If the player goes to sleep in the lake, they will encounter Dr. Blanchet on one of her nightly swims.

